

```

    usepackagefontspec
defaultfontfeaturesLigatures=TeX,Scale=MatchLowercase
setmainfontTeX Gyre Pagella
setsansfontTeX Gyre Heros

    usepackagegeometry
geometrypaperwidth=6in,paperheight=9in,inner=1in,outer=0.9in,top=1in,bottom=1in,headsep=12pt,h

    usepackagecolor
definecolorCWAaccentHTML2E6BB2
definecolorCWAaccent2HTMLB2524A
definecolorCWGrayHTML6B6B6B
definecolorsepiaHTML704214
definecolorgoldHTMLD4AF37
definecolorparchmentHTMLFBF1E8

    usepackagemicrotype
usepackagegraphicx
usepackage tikz
usetikzlibrarycalc,decorations.pathmorphing,shadows,positioning,fit
usepackage tikzpagenodes
usepackagepgfornament
usepackagefancyhdr
usepackagetitlesec
usepackageeverypage
usepackagelettrine
usepackagecolorbox
tcbuselibrarybreakable
usepackage lipsum

    emergencystretch=3em
raggedbottom

    newcommand
TopLocationText
newcommand
BottomLocationText

    newcommand
TopLandscapeDefault
begin tikzpicture[x=
textwidth,y=1cm,baseline]
fill[CWAaccent!20] (0,0) .. controls (0.12,0.6) and (0.28,0.35) .. (0.45,0.65) ..
controls (0.62,0.95) and (0.78,0.3) .. (1,0) -- (1,1.2) -- (0,1.2) -- cycle;
fill[CWAaccent!35] (0,0.2) .. controls (0.22,0.7) and (0.38,0.25) .. (0.57,0.6)
.. controls (0.75,0.9) and (0.95,0.35) .. (1,0.45) -- (1,1.2) -- (0,1.2) -- cycle;
ifx
TopLocationText
empty
else
node[anchor=south west,font=
sffamily
small
bfseries
colorCWGray] at (0.02,0.12)
TopLocationText;
fi
end tikzpicture

```

```

TopLandscapeContent
TopLandscapeDefault
newcommand
BottomLandscapeContent
BottomLandscapeDefault
newcommand
setTopLandscape[1]
renewcommand
TopLandscapeContent1
newcommand
setBottomLandscape[1]
renewcommand
BottomLandscapeContent1
newcommand
setTopLocation[1]
renewcommand
TopLocationText1
newcommand
setBottomLocation[1]
renewcommand
BottomLocationText1
    newcommand
POVMarker[3][1.8em]
tikz[baseline=(char.base)]
node[draw=none, circle, fill=2, text=white, inner sep=0pt, minimum size=1]
(char)
sffamily
bfseries
small 3;
newcommand
POVGraphic[1]
raisebox-0.12
baselineskip
includegraphics[height=1.8em]1
    newcommand
CurrentPOV
POVMarker[1.6em]CWGray?
newcommand
setPOV[1]
renewcommand

```

CurrentPOV1
 newcommand
 setPOVName[1]
 def
 CurrentPOVName1
 newcommand
 AliceSymbol
 POVMarker[2.0em]CWAaccentA
 newcommand
 RavenSymbol
 POVMarker[2.0em]CWAaccent2R
 newcommand
 NullSymbol
 POVMarker[2.0em]CWGray?
 newcommand
 ScenePOV
 noindent
 CurrentPOV
 enspace
 fancyhf
 fancyhead[LE,RO]
 CurrentPOV
 fancyhead[C]
 TopLandscapeContent
 fancyfoot[C]
 BottomLandscapeContent
 fancyfoot[LE,RO]
 thepage
 renewcommand
 headrulewidth0pt
 renewcommand
 footrulewidth0pt
 pagestylefancy
 newcounterCWTotChapters
 newcommand
 SetTotalChapters[1]
 setcounterCWTotChapters1
 SetTotalChapters0
 AddEveryPageHook
 ifnum

```

valueCWTotallChapters;0
ifnum
valuechapter;0
begin tikzpicture[remember picture,overlay]
ifodd
valuepage
coordinate (sttop) at (current page text area.north east);
coordinate (stbot) at (current page text area.south east);
def
xshift6mm
else
coordinate (sttop) at (current page text area.north west);
coordinate (stbot) at (current page text area.south west);
def
xshift-6mm
fi
fill[CWAccent!65] ((sttop) + (
xshift,0)) rectangle ((stbot) + (
xshift-4mm,0));
pgfmathtruncatemacro
nchap
valueCWTotallChapters
foreach
i in 1,...,
nchap
pgfmathsetmacro
tifthenelse(
nchap;1, (
i-1)/(
nchap-1), 0.5)
coordinate (mark) at ((sttop)!
t!(stbot));
coordinate (markout) at ((mark) + (
xshift-2mm,0));
ifnum
i=
valuechapter
draw[fill=white, draw=CWAccent, line width=0.9pt] (markout) circle (1.6mm);
else
draw[fill=white!85, draw=CWAccent!30] (markout) circle (0.9mm);

```

```

fi
node[rotate=90, font=
sffamily
bfseries, text=white] at ((sttop)!0.5!(stbot) + (
xshift - 9mm, 0))
thechapter;
endtikzpicture
fi
fi
    titleformat
chapter[display]
centering
normalfont
Huge
bfseries
vspace*-1em
CurrentPOV
quad
Huge
thechapter 0.5em
centering [
vspace1em
hrule
vspace1em]
    newtcolorboxquoteboxenhanced,breakable,colback=sepia!8,colframe=gold!60,left=3mm,right=3mm,t
west=3pt0ptgold!65,before=
begingroup
sloppy,after=
endgroup
    newcommand
scenebreak
par
bigskip
begincenter
pgfornament[width=2.2em]88
endcenter
bigskip
    setlength
parindent1.25em
setlength

```

parskip0.5em

NorthDawnKeyDawnKey!40!cyan NorthDawnMidDawnMid!50!blue NorthDawnShadeDawnShade!60!darkblue

NorthMorningKeyMorningKey!35!cyan NorthMorningMidMorningMid!45!blue NorthMorningShadeMorningShade!55!darkblue

NorthNoonKeyNoonKey!30!white NorthNoonMidNoonMid!40!lightgray NorthNoonShadeNoonShade!50!darkgray

NorthAfternoonKeyAfternoonKey!35!cyan NorthAfternoonMidAfternoonMid!45!blue NorthAfternoonShadeAfternoonShade!55!darkblue

NorthSunsetKeySunsetKey!45!magenta NorthSunsetMidSunsetMid!40!blue NorthSunsetShadeSunsetShade!55!darkblue

NorthDuskKeyDuskKey!50!darkblue NorthDuskMidDuskMid!55!darkblue NorthDuskShadeDuskShade!70!black

NorthNightKeyNightKey!40!black NorthNightMidNightMid!50!black NorthNightShadeNightShade!90!black

SouthDawnKeyDawnKey!20!yellow SouthDawnMidDawnMid!30!green SouthDawnShadeDawnShade!35!darkgreen

SouthMorningKeyMorningKey!25!yellow SouthMorningMidMorningMid!35!green SouthMorningShadeMorningShade!40!darkgreen

SouthNoonKeyNoonKey!15!yellow SouthNoonMidNoonMid!25!green SouthNoonShadeNoonShade!30!darkgreen

SouthAfternoonKeyAfternoonKey!20!orange SouthAfternoonMidAfternoonMid!30!green SouthAfternoonShadeAfternoonShade!35!darkgreen

SouthSunsetKeySunsetKey!15!orange SouthSunsetMidSunsetMid!20!red SouthSunsetShadeSouthSunsetMid!50!darkgreen

SouthDuskKeyDuskKey!30!orange SouthDuskMidDuskMid!35!red SouthDuskShadeDuskShade!45!darkgreen

SouthNightKeyNightKey!25!darkgreen SouthNightMidNightMid!35!darkgreen SouthNightShadeNightShade!80!darkgreen

EastDawnKeyDawnKey!25!magenta EastDawnMidDawnMid!35!yellow EastDawnShadeDawnShade!40!purple

EastMorningKeyMorningKey!20!magenta EastMorningMidMorningMid!30!yellow EastMorningShadeMorningShade!35!purple

EastNoonKeyNoonKey!20!magenta EastNoonMidNoonMid!25!yellow EastNoonShadeNoonShade!35!purple

EastAfternoonKeyAfternoonKey!15!magenta EastAfternoonMidAfternoonMid!25!yellow EastAfternoonShadeAfternoonShade!35!purple

EastSunsetKeySunsetKey!20!magenta EastSunsetMidSunsetMid!30!yellow EastSunsetShadeSunsetShade!40!purple

EastDuskKeyDuskKey!35!magenta EastDuskMidDuskMid!40!purple East-
 DuskShadeDuskShade!55!purple
 EastNightKeyNightKey!35!purple EastNightMidNightMid!45!purple East-
 NightShadeNightShade!75!purple
 WestDawnKeyDawnKey!30!brown WestDawnMidDawnMid!35!orange West-
 DawnShadeDawnShade!40!brown
 WestMorningKeyMorningKey!25!brown WestMorningMidMorningMid!30!orange
 WestMorningShadeMorningShade!35!brown
 WestNoonKeyNoonKey!35!brown WestNoonMidNoonMid!40!orange West-
 NoonShadeNoonShade!45!brown
 WestAfternoonKeyAfternoonKey!30!brown WestAfternoonMidAfternoon-
 Mid!35!orange WestAfternoonShadeAfternoonShade!40!brown
 WestSunsetKeySunsetKey!20!red WestSunsetMidSunsetMid!25!orange West-
 SunsetShadeSunsetShade!35!brown
 WestDuskKeyDuskKey!40!brown WestDuskMidDuskMid!40!brown West-
 DuskShadeDuskShade!50!brown
 WestNightKeyNightKey!30!brown WestNightMidNightMid!40!brown West-
 NightShadeNightShade!70!brown
 CentDawnKeyDawnKey CentDawnMidDawnMid CentDawnShadeDawn-
 Shade
 CentMorningKeyMorningKey CentMorningMidMorningMid CentMorn-
 ingShadeMorningShade
 CentNoonKeyNoonKey CentNoonMidNoonMid CentNoonShadeNoonShade
 CentAfternoonKeyAfternoonKey CentAfternoonMidAfternoonMid CentAfter-
 noonShadeAfternoonShade
 CentSunsetKeySunsetKey CentSunsetMidSunsetMid CentSunsetShadeSun-
 setShade
 CentDuskKeyDuskKey CentDuskMidDuskMid CentDuskShadeDuskShade
 CentNightKeyNightKey CentNightMidNightMid CentNightShadeNight-
 Shade

3 The Grey Mountains · Dusk Valley of Ashenveil · Twilight

APart I: The Grey Mountains

AELINDRA

[lines=3]The wind came down from the Grey Mountains carrying the smell of burnt cedar and something older—something that had no name in the common tongue, but which every soldier recognised in the hollow of their ribs. Aelindra tightened the strap of her vambrace and said nothing.

Below, the valley curved like a wound in the earth, its floor dark with the remnants of what had been three villages not a fortnight past. The smoke still rose in thin, patient threads, as though the ground itself had not yet

decided whether to forgive. She counted the fires. Seven. No—eight, if the far glow past the treeline was theirs and not some shepherd's accident.

Eight fires meant a column, not a raid. A column meant orders. Orders meant someone, somewhere, had decided this particular valley was worth the cost of making it into a memory.

Aelindra had spent seventeen years learning the difference between decisions made in rooms and decisions that lived in the soil afterward. She had yet to find a word for the distance between them.

"We should not have come this way," said the boy behind her. She did not turn. The boy said many true things. That was what made him dangerous to keep near and impossible to send away.

"The path chooses itself," she said. It was not an answer, but the boy was learning to accept answers that were not answers at all.

"The path chooses itself. The traveller merely walks where choice has led them. Such is the burden of command—to walk the path and pretend it was never chosen at all."

—Aelindra's Journal, Third Year of the War

When the boy began speaking again, she simply raised her hand. Some silences were deeper than words. The smoke rose. The wind carried ash and the scent of endings. And Aelindra, who had given all her years to preventing catastrophe, watched it unfold anyway in the valleys below.

RThe Scout's Return

RAVEN

[lines=3]The courier horses were near exhaustion when they came pounding down the mountain pass. Raven watched from the outcropping, counting them: three riders, all in the colours of the western garrison, all riding hard enough to kill their mounts. That meant news. Bad news. The kind that made commanders ride for three days straight without rest.

He slipped down the rock face with the ease of long practice, moving through shadows like water. The horses hadn't seen him. The riders wouldn't either until he wanted them to.

The scout's trade was learned slowly and forgotten quickly once you stopped paying attention. Raven wasn't the sort to stop paying attention.

By sunfall, he would have their message. By the following dawn, he would know everything they knew, and perhaps a few things they didn't. That was why Aelindra kept him close, despite the other captains' misgivings. A good scout could see around corners. A great scout could see around time itself.

Raven was, by his own estimation, somewhere in between.

The lead rider's horse stumbled. Raven found himself frowning at that—they might have to walk the last three miles if the animal went lame. That would delay the message. That might change everything.

"In the end, it's never the sword that matters. It's what you know, and when you know it, and whether you're willing to act on knowledge come what may."

—A saying among the scouts

He stayed where he was, hidden, watching. Already his mind was weaving possibilities: if the news was what he suspected, then Aelindra would need to move the garrison by nightfall. If she moved the garrison, the supply lines would break for a day at least. If the supply lines broke...

The chain of consequence was long. Raven had learned to follow it far enough to matter.

The Mystic's Vision

SEREN

[lines=3]Seren saw the world in layers—the physical world of stone and soil and burning wood, and beneath that, the world of story, the world of meaning, the world that most people stumbled through blind. In the tower room, sitting before the scrying pool, she saw both layers at once.

What came was not a vision like the ones the old texts described. It was subtler. It was the way the light shifted on the water's surface. The way a single ripple seemed to contain a whole geometry of consequences.

Something had changed. The weight of the world had shifted, almost imperceptibly, but she felt it in the root of her skull, in the deepest parts of her gift.

The garrison would move. That much was clear in the way the future seemed to thin and fold. Aelindra would move them. And in moving, she would unweave something that had been woven very carefully, very deliberately, over nearly a generation.

Seren rose from the pool and steadied herself against the stone rim. The visions never left her whole. They took pieces—a moment of clarity for a week of headaches, a glimpse of tomorrow for a day of muddled thinking.

She walked to the tower window and looked out over the valley. From here, in the thin place where the veil wore worn, she could see the smoke from eight fires.

But she could also see the shadows moving beneath them. The cold gathering at the edges of things. The breath of something vast and patient, waiting in the spaces between.

“The gift of sight is also the curse of knowing. Once you have seen what comes, you cannot unsee it, and you cannot prevent it. You can only choose how you stand when it arrives.”

—Seren's Testament

The boy would come to the tower by nightfall. Everything hinged on what the boy would choose to do when he understood the full truth of what had been set in motion. For now, she could only wait, and watch, and carry her knowledge like a stone in her chest.